

Works as popular today as the Violin Concerto, the Piano Concerto No. 1, Eugene Onegin, and the ballet scores took a long time to be accepted. It was the 1812 Overture, written in 1880 at the suggestion of Nikolai Rubinstein to commemorate Russia's victory over Napoleon, that made Tchaikovsky a household name—even though he had always hated the piece.

International acclaim

Through the early 1880s, the now celebrated Tchaikovsky traveled widely and wrote prolifically. In 1885, he bought a house in the countryside near Klin, outside Moscow, where he declared himself “cheerful, contented and at peace.” Works of this period included his operas *Cherevichki* and *The Enchantress*, plus the “*Manfred*” Symphony, based on Byron's poem.

The premiere of *Cherevichki* was his first attempt at conducting, which proved a splendid addition to his career. He conducted a highly successful concert of his own music in Moscow, then undertook a substantial European tour, meeting Brahms, Grieg, and Dvořák en route. In 1891, he conducted the first concert at the brand-new Carnegie Hall, New York.

In Russia, his new compositions included the Fifth Symphony and the ballet *Sleeping Beauty*—the latter was developed in close collaboration with the choreographer Marius Petipa and premiered at the Mariinsky Ballet, St. Petersburg, in 1890. Tchaikovsky was disappointed, though, by the cooler reception for his opera *The Queen of Spades*, which he regarded as one of his finest.

In his later years, Tchaikovsky became a national treasure and